

FEMALE SERVITUDE AND REVELATION IN ANITA NAIR'S *LADIES COUPE*

K. Parasakthi, Guest Lecturer, Government arts and science college, Mullipuram, Kangeyam

Anita Nair, the popular Indian English Writer has captured quite a few Indian hearts in her fifteen years of career as a writer. She goes through myriad roles as a content writer, novelist, essayist, poet with her unique way of getting into details. Rural Kerala is much depicted in her novels in which she says about her deep connection with her motherland. But she rules out the possibility of a nostalgic writer as she writes on different subjects. The way she shapes her characters, each one an absolute blend of emotions and myriad sensitivities, the way she effortlessly structures the metaphorical expression, and the way she weaves meticulous descriptions in her stories and stimulates the readers imagination till the very last paragraph.

In *Ladies Coupe*, there are five women along with the protagonist Akhilandeswari. Each chapter of the novel is devoted to one of the women's stories. The novel starts with Akhila who is introduced as a single forty-five years old, without rose-coloured spectacles, without husband, children, home and family, dreaming of escape and space, hungry for life and experience and aching to connect. She is an official in the Income Tax Department. One day she sets out to seek certain answers for herself, mainly to the question whether a single woman can live alone, away from her family.

She buys a ticket to Kanyakumari and is placed in ladies coupe along with five other women giving her company for the overnight journey. These women share their life experiences with her, thus helping her to gain her full potential as a woman and grapple with the answers to the questions she's been asking so long.

The novel does not deal with one story. It deals with the lives and experiences of six women which have been welded together by author into a skillful whole, with Akhila or Akhilandeswari as a magnet centre. The story of each woman provides a learning experience for Akhila who contemplates upon the various aspects of her life after each session of tale-telling. It helps her to break free from manifold identities as daughter, sister, aunt and provider. In the novel, this is the first time, she is thinking, about herself. She has started a journey to Kanyakumari, which is according to her a

place of Kanyakumari, the goddess, like her, had put her life on hold. (LC 3) Through this external journey she has also gone through the interior journey and tries to assimilate her scatter identity. She has spent the prime time of her life in thinking, caring and providing good life to her family (two brothers, sister and her mother) after the death of her father as she promised herself, "I provide for you tonight, I will have to provide for the family you abandoned so callously." (LC 59) As Indra Devi says.

"Anita Nair probably hints at the family's easy acceptance of her as the head of the family on a place traditionally reserved for the patriarch in both the colonial and post-colonial periods" (220).

Though she is the provider of the family, she is not considered as the head of the family and her needs and desires are least bothered. Being the eldest son and the man of the family Narsi, does not ask for anybody's permission to get married but "decided" to get married for "Narsi decided he wanted to get married" (LC 77). When he tells the family that he is going to marry the principal's daughter, no one could find fault with his choice and there was nothing anyone could say except perhaps - Don't you think you should wait for your elder sister to get married before you think of a wife and a family? But who has to mouth this rebuke? (LC 77).

Both Narayan and Narsi have their weddings in the small hall, on the same day and time. No one comes forward to reduce her burden of responsibility when they become mature. As she regrets that Amma and her brothers never ask something about her marriage, "What about you? You've been the head of this family ever since Appa died. Don't you want a husband, children, and a home of your own? In their minds Akhila had ceased to be a woman and had already metamorphosed into spinster. (LC 77). Though Akhila has done her duties, all that of a head of a family to her brothers and sister, she is not recognized as the real head, just because she is a woman. Amma expects her to get permission from her brothers, the men of the family go on an office tour. On the other hand they are taking her journey otherwise. As Padma's eyes glint with doubts that "Is she traveling alone or is someone going with her? A man perhaps." (LC 5) So she tries to warn her "I don't know what Narayan Amma and Narsi Amma will say when they know of your going away suddenly and all by yourself too ..." (LC 7). Padma is taking the decision in this way because she belongs to a very orthodox Brahmin family where all the decision

are taken by male as their mother once told them about their father's nature: " ... Don't you know how strict he is? He told me when we were first married I want my wife to take of my children .and me." (LC 13)

Their mother told them also that in marriage, there is no equality. What Akhila misses the most is that no one calls her by her name anyone any more. Her brothers and sister have always called her Akka (Elder sister). At work, her colleagues call her Madam, "All women are Madam and men are Sir. And Aroma bad taken to addressing her as Am.madi .. As though to call Akb:ila by her name would be an affront to her head-of - the-household status." (LC 84).

The story of Akhila reminds the readers about the Indian female situation where she is estimated to spend her time to execute the role of the daughter, sister and breadwinner of the family to gratify their requirements. But when she begins to ask about her right, happiness and identity, she is taken otherwise. As Akhila gets out of control and ask over her. "So who was Akhilandeswari? Did she exist at all? If she did, what was her identity? Did her heart skip a beat when she saw a mango tree studded with blossoms? Did the feel of rain on her bare akin send a line of goose bumps down her spine ... T" (LC 84). This negligence makes her revolutionary as she chides Padma, "This is my house and if I wish to cat eggs here or prance around naked, I will do so. If someone doesn't care for it, they are free to leave." (LC 162) The same happens with other women's case in the novel.

The story of Margaret Shanthi reminds the readers how women are dominated by man-power. Men like Ebenezer Paulraj are not able to see and admire the value of his wife. Margaret marries Ebenezer PauJraj at her own choice and at the immediate eagerness of her family. She is a Chemistry teacher not a normal teacher but the one who has been a gold medalist. Initially Margaret does not understand the deep rooted male egoism in Ebenezer Paulraj, as her great love for him has made her blind.

Though at times she feels the pain of it she convinces herself saying, "He was Ebe. My Ebe. He was right. He was always right". (LC109). Ebe is simply a male-bigot

who takes the power to ask Margaret to abort the baby off, the baby off, when she conveys him the good news with all happiness, "just think of this as a tumour that has to be removed." (LC106). Not only in that, but he continues to push upon his supremacy over her in deciding her higher studies, career and even simple things like choice of food and her hair dressing for he says, '~what's the point of working for a doctorate? Do your B.Ed. so you can become a teacher and then we will always be together. Long hair doesn't suit you. Cut it off. You'll look nicer with your hair in a blunt bob." (LC 105).

Margaret begins to feel suffocation in this authoritative environment and asks herself like Akhila, "where was I in all this? Margaret Shanthi, the women. In Ebe's eyes, had I ceased to be? What did he see me as? A little girl he could rule and mould, make love to and jolly around?" (LC 111).

Even parents are more concerned about the boys than the girls. Anita Nair has chosen the character of Prabha Devi to emphasize this issue. When Prabha Devi was born his father sighs, as it would be an obstacle for his business growth as he says, ..Has this baby, apart from ruining my business plans, addled your brains as weU? If you ask me, a daughter is a bloody nuisance." (LC 169). Even Prabha Devi's mother is delighted when a daughter is born as her thoughts are confined that a daughter is someone who will take her recipes to the other house and treasure her jewellery and someone who will say that she did this and that in her mother's house. She is brought up as a traditional Indian girl and after marriage she is supposed to be a good house wife This treatment of her parents and husband compels Prabha to think, "Am I not a person by myself? Am I to be treated as a mere extension of someone else's personality? Jagdeesh's Mrs and no more." (LC 180).

The youngest of the six members of coupe is Sheela, fourteen years old. Anita Nair has not only brought out the need to state the individual of the female selfhood but also finely brought out the issue of female child abuse through the character depiction of Sheela As Judcs and Jalaja and Shunmuga Sundari observe, "Sheela's retrospection also touches on sexual abuse of girl children by older men." (LC 122). Sheela feels embarrassed and hurt at the unnecessary touching of Hasina's father Nazar as. One Sunday afternoon when Sheela went to their house, rushing in from the heat with a line

of sweat beading her upper lip, Nazar had reached forward and wiped it with his forefinger. The touch of his finger tingled on her skin for a long time. (LC 66).

So Sheela was not unable to open her mouth against the physical abuse attempted on her, but developed confidence to protect her from it in future for It is said, "Thereafter Sheela mopped her face with a hanky each time she entered Hasinji's home." (LC 66). Even Sheela's friend Hasina and her mother are not able to understand the man's attempt to touch her unnecessarily but they are helpless. Once Nazar jangled the bows in her sleeves, "she saw the hurt in Hasina and her mother's eyes." (LC 66).

Thereafter Sheela takes the right decision that "she would never go to Hasina's house again" (LC 66) as a means of her self-defence because she comes to know about an incident through her grandmother, where a girl named Celine became a victim to a man's impulse. Celine became pregnant because of her friend's father and her family moved to a place where no one would know about her abortion. But it is said, "the friend's father went to a far away town where he would find plenty of young girls to ruin everyone said" (LC 65).

Through this incident, Nair has brought out the unfair treatment of women by men. Marikolanthu is the most pitiable woman among the six. She represents poor and miserable peasantry class women on whom male brutality is forced on heavily and left unquestioned. Even as a girl she is deprived of to be sent to the town school as her mother says, "It's not just the money but how can I send a young girl by herself there is too much at risk.." (LC 215). To make sure her mother's dread, her childhood innocence is crushed when Murugesan attempts physical cruelty on her. When she is found pregnant her mother and Sujata, regret it as they just feel it is too late to insist Murugesan to marry her. Her mother is least worried about her feelings but worries that no one will marry her. Even when the issue is taken to the Chettiar's son Sridhar, he with little unwillingness says, "The girl must have led him on and now that she is pregnant she's making up a story about rape." (LC 245). For her mother and Sujata, a woman's life and guard lies in her husband, as Sujata says. "But if she has a job, that will replace a husband's protection." (LC 246).

But Marikolanthu is able to raise the question within her about the so called "Husband's protection. She is sure that neither her mother nor Sujata have their husbands' look out for them, but for them, "a fulfilled woman was one who had married" (LC 246). For Marikolanthu nothing is crueler than a man's raping of a woman and so she finds little fault in the missy's live for each other and experiences a kind of content and happiness to give her love for Sujata, more than her husband does. Marikolanthu never wants attach up her life with a husband. Till she is thirty - one she lives alone and struggles with life, making a living of her own. She neither wants to depend upon her brothers nor wants money from Sujata or her husband but decides to make her living of her own, working as a servant maid in a house.

Thus Anita Nair has touched all the major aspects of female world in this novel whether it is the case of girl-child, physical humiliation, rape and the dominating role of male in female's decision. She has discussed all the problems of all the facets of female life and portraits pragmatically how their desires, rights and happiness crush in disguise of duty. Neither she advocates that women will remain subjugated nor the victims under patriarch system nor in favour of rejecting the existence of male's importance in female's life. But they should react in their own way against the wrong treatment from male side. Janaki Prabhakar, the old woman in the coupe whose relationship with her husband is a "friendly love", tells about herself, "i am a woman who has always been looked after. First there was my father, and my brother; then my husband, when my husband is gone, there will be my son." (LC 22).

She is happy with this treatment because she thinks that "Why should a woman live by herself? There is always a man who is willing to be with her." (LC 21). Prabha Devi, the rich docile wife who loves swimming because it symbolically, gives her a sense of achievement. As she confesses "for the first time in many years, you are doing what do you want and not what everyone else thinks you ought to want, she told herself sternly!"(LC 87).

Margaret Paulraj, the chemistry teacher who succeeds in "discipline" her egotistic husband and changes him according to her choice Now "he needed me like he had never before and Ebe became a man I could live with once again."(LC 134).

Sheela, the fourteen years old girl whose understanding of her dying grandmother paves the way for own future freedom and Marikolanthu, whose rape, plainly and symbolically, attached with extreme poverty and class exploitation is on the peak of all other stories.

Anita Nair not only depicts the realistic picture of women's condition but also delivers the message in the novel through many characters as Karpagam. Who is a widow but unlike other widows she wears the kumkum and colourful clothes. She is an audacious woman, who breaks the chains of patriarchy when she says,

I don't care what my family or anyone thinks. I am who I am. And I have as much right as anyone else to live as I choose. Tell me didn't we as young girls wear colourful clothes and Jewellery and a bottu? It has nothing to do with whether she is married or not and whether her husband is alive or dead.

Who made these laws anyway? Some man who couldn't bear the thought that in spite of his death, his wife continued to be attractive to other men. (LC 202).

She tries to wake up Akhila and says firmly "If I can live alone, why can't you?"(LC 201). She influences Akhila so much that realizes: " Karpagam, are you real or are you some goddess who has come here to lead me out of this." (LC 202). Margaret also advises Akhila that "You 'll discover that once you stop worrying what the world will think of you, your life will become that much easier to live." (L-C 136). Marikolanthu, the worst victim of patriarchy puts the best examples in front of Akhiia, She tells her "what do they know of how cruel the world can be to women? I am not telling you that women are weak. Women are strong. Women can do everything as men. Women can do much more. But a woman has to seek that vein of strength in her. It does not show itself naturally." (LC 210). In the coupe, after exchanging the feelings with one-another, Akhila feels very light and decides to live according to her own way. Thus the journey by train freshens up not only Akhila's daily routine but also her inner self.

The journey implies both a physical escape from the patriarchal world she has inhabited (and this has involved the use of her individual will) and also the

stereotypical metaphoric value invariably attached to the concept of the journey - that of experimental growth and an expansion of horizons. The combined experiences of her co-passengers help Akhila to develop the new confidence that marks her behavior after she disembarks. The metaphor of the journey is further developed into the metaphor of the destination - Kanyakumari is a seaside town with the grand vista of the meeting of three seas.

The openness of the scene symbolizes the range of possibilities open to Akhila. The AkhiJa who was trapped in her family situation in a small land-locked town in Tamilnadu now -sits gazing at an azure sky and playing with the sand. Three oceans meet and mingle at her feet, she realizes with exhilaration. Her realization of her own independence is epiphanic.

In Kanyakumari, Akhila tests her newfound confidence by taking a lover. That she is able to manage the little encounter entirely on her own terms amuses her. She smiles, "because she discovers it is so easy to smile now that she has her life where she wants it to be." (LC 275) "Akhila has no more fears. Why then should she walk with a downcast head?" She books a call to Hari. He might be married, he might have moved on. Still, it is worth the effort. She loves Hari "but she desires life more." If he is available and interested, life could take a turn for the better. If not, well ... the narrative is open-ended. Hari does answer the call but Nair does not choose to tell us what he says. Whatever it is, a new Akhila has been born - one determined to be heard and noticed, capable of building a good life for her.

REFERENCES

1. Deora, Sreya. Women through History: Subjugation, Emancipation and Social Movements
2. Nair, Anita. Ladies Coupe. New Delhi: Penguin Books India. 2001
3. Sinha, Sunitha. Post-colonial women writers New Perspectives, New Delhi: Atlantic Publishers and Distributors, 2008.
4. Tharakan, Sophie M. and Michael Tharakan. Status of Women in India: A Historical Perspective. Social Scientist Vol. 4, No. 4/5, Special Number on Women. 1975, pp. 115-123 5. <https://www.jstor.org/stable/3516124>

5. <https://feminisminindia.com/2022/03/10/marital-inequality-traditions-subjugating-women/>
6. Nivethabraba, R. "Unpacking Toni Morrison's Literary Universe." Research Journal of English (RJOE), vol. 11, no. 1, Jan.–Mar. 2026, Oray's Publications, doi:10.36993/RJOE.2026.11.01.268.
7. Nivethabraba, R. Mother of the House: Exploring Flora Nwapa's Efuru's Legacy, International Journal of Trends in English Language and Literature (IJTELL) An International Peer-Reviewed English Journal; ISSN:2582-8487 Impact Factor: 8.486(SJIF);www.ijtell.com Volume-7, Issue-1;Jan-Mar(2026), DOI:10.53413/IJTELL.2026.71045